

External drives test

66 We try and solve your external hard drive and flash drive buying conundrum through this article

Bazaar

76 The latest, greatest and most anticipated products in the market reviewed with a score to rate their calibre



Ahoy Maties!

13 HD Media Players

walk the plank...

Avast ye landlubbers, perched in fore o' yer HDTV without anythin' t' watch. 'Tis time ye got yersef one o' these...

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Stop denying it. Most of us with broad band internet have a lot of movies, TV serials, and more stored on our computers. Terabytes of it in some cases. For arguments' sake, let's assume you have only downloaded or ripped DVDs and Blurays that you have already purchased, and this collection of yours is merely a legal backup. It's not right to pirate, we all know it, and yet as hard as you try, you end up playing pirate.

OK, so moving beyond the pirate tag for now, we come across the next fork in the road towards entertainment bliss. You have all your movies, probably stored on a PC/laptop or on an external hard drive (*we've tested those too this month, see page 66*), now how do you get it from there to your HDTV?

Shiver me timbers, the reason you bought the darn thing for so many doubloons was to be able to kick back with your lass, some grog in your hand, and watch your favourite flicks. But nay, instead you squint at your PC/laptop screen, two feet from yer nose, straining to hear

what Jack Sparrow says on his way to Davy Jones Locker! Far from ideal this.

That's where HD media players come in. Just plug in a hard drive, memory card, pen drive, or basically any USB storage, and play back files stored on it. Some even have integrated Ethernet ports or Wi-Fi, to enable you to do it all over the wires/air, DLNA style! If the ability to create home networks is not enough, some of these also throw in the ability to stream from noted web services, effectively turning your HDTV into a smart device at a fraction of the cost...

FINDING THE CREW

The categories

The thirteen HD media players we got were lined up for inspection, belts tightened, shoes spit polished, and hooks attached to stubs. It became pretty obvious that four groups were emerging.

It would be mighty unfair to pit sprogs against buccaneers, and thus we looked at specs to decide what these four categories should be.

The first category is for the entry-level media players, which do not offer any extras such as Ethernet connectivity or built-in Wi-Fi. The second category has devices with web access